

CRITICAL ESSAY

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The Long Shadow of Night and Fog

Bureaucratic Legibility, Dehumanisation, and the Lineage of the Surveillance State

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Portfolio note

This essay reads Alain Resnais' 1956 documentary *Night and Fog* through James C. Scott's *Seeing Like a State*, then traces the bureaucratic logic the film records into present-day surveillance, including in Bangladesh. I wanted to build a conceptual argument with the historic event and its local application.

Introduction

Alain Resnais made *Night and Fog* in 1956, eleven years after the camps were liberated, walking his camera through the grassed-over ruins of Auschwitz and Majdanek and cutting between that quiet present and the archival horror of the past. The film is usually discussed as a work of memory. I want to read it differently: as a visual record of an administrative system. What Resnais documents, beneath the atrocity, is paperwork — registers, categories, sorting, the conversion of human beings into entries in a ledger. Read that way, the film becomes a case study in something James C. Scott would describe four decades later in *Seeing Like a State* (1998): the drive of the modern state to make its population legible, and the violence that legibility can license.

Scott's argument is that states cannot govern what they cannot see, and so they remodel society into forms that can be measured, counted, and administered from the centre — standardised names, mapped land, gridded settlements, simplified categories. He calls these “state simplifications,” and his point is not that legibility is inherently evil but that it strips away the local detail and human texture that make people more than data, and that this stripping-away, joined to coercive power and a confident planning ideology, has repeatedly produced catastrophe (Scott, 1998). *Night and Fog* shows what the far end of that process looks like. This essay traces the argument in three movements: the film as an image of imposed order, the historical machinery of categorisation it depended on, and the continuity between that machinery and the surveillance systems operating now — including in my own country.

1. The Design of Exclusion

Early in the film, Resnais' camera moves slowly across the geometry of the camp: the parallel rows of barracks, the watchtowers set at measured intervals, the fence lines running straight to the horizon. It is a landscape built to be seen from a single vantage point. This is legibility rendered in architecture. Scott argues that the high-modernist state prefers the grid because the grid is administratively convenient — it can be surveyed, subdivided, and supervised with minimal friction (Scott, 1998). The camp is that preference taken to its limit: a space designed so that every inmate is always potentially visible, and so that the population can be moved, counted, and processed as uniform units.

Eyal Weizman's work on what he calls forensic architecture makes the same point about the present. Analysing the Syrian regime prison at Saydnaya, Weizman shows how a building can be an instrument rather than merely a container — how the organisation of space, sound, and sightlines becomes a technology of control and terror in its own right (Weizman, 2017). The camp Resnais films and the prison Weizman reconstructs share a design philosophy: build the environment so that domination is structural, embedded in walls and angles, not dependent on any single guard's attention. The architecture does the watching.

2. The Machinery of Categorisation

Legibility needs more than architecture; it needs a filing system. The most disturbing sequences in *Night and Fog* are the ones that show the camp as an information-processing operation — the sorting of arrivals, the registration, the SS administration watching over it all. Behind that bureaucratic calm sat a real technology, and its history is documented in Edwin Black's *IBM and the Holocaust* (2001).

Black's research traces how the Nazi state used Hollerith punch-card machines, supplied and serviced through IBM's German subsidiary, to identify, track, and manage populations across occupied Europe. Each concentration-camp prisoner was assigned a five-digit Hollerith number; that number followed the prisoner from one labour assignment to the next, reported back to a central inmate file (Black, 2001). At

Auschwitz the system left its mark on the body itself — the tattoo on the forearm began as an IBM tracking number. Processed prisoner cards were stamped “Hollerith erfasst,” Hollerith registered. And the system encoded human fate as a category: a prisoner who had been killed was recorded under code six (Black, 2001). The bureaucratic terminology of the camp documents is precisely what Scott means by state simplification — a person reduced to a punched hole, a fate reduced to a digit.

Black’s thesis is contested, and intellectual honesty requires saying so. The Auschwitz-Birkenau State Museum’s longtime head of research, Franciszek Piper, has disputed that Hollerith machines were physically operated at Auschwitz itself, suggesting Black may have over-read the “Hollerith registered” stamps on prisoner documents (Auschwitz-Birkenau State Museum). The dispute is worth holding onto, because it marks the boundary of what the evidence supports: that the Nazi extermination apparatus depended on punch-card data processing is well established; the exact placement of particular machines remains argued over. Either way, the conceptual point stands. The Holocaust was not only a crime of hatred; it was a crime of administration, and the administration ran on the conversion of people into data.

This is the heart of what Resnais’ film and Scott’s theory share. Primo Levi, who survived Auschwitz, titled his memoir *If This Is a Man* (1959) — a question the bureaucratic machine had already answered in the negative, by treating the prisoner not as a man but as a unit of labour to be logged until it stopped being useful. The reduction of the human to the categorisable is the mechanism that makes mass atrocity administratively possible. You do not have to confront a person to process a number.

3. From Punch Card to Data Packet

The unsettling argument of this essay is that the logic did not end in 1945. It changed instruments. The punch card became the database; the Hollerith number became the digital identifier; the central inmate file became the data centre. Scott’s warning about legibility was written about agrarian and industrial states, but it reads now like a description of the data state, in which the capacity to see the population has expanded beyond anything the SS administration could have built.

That expansion is global, and it is not confined to authoritarian regimes. Ariane Ollier-Malaterre, whose study *Living with Digital Surveillance in China* (2023) examines how ordinary Chinese citizens narrate life under pervasive monitoring, made the point directly in a December 2024 SOAS webinar on the book: digital surveillance, she argued, is not a uniquely Chinese phenomenon but a worldwide one, differing across societies in degree and in the stories people tell themselves about it rather than in kind. The technologies of legibility have become ambient — woven into phones, platforms, and payment systems — in ways that make Scott’s “seeing” nearly continuous.

Bangladesh is part of this story, and as a journalist I have watched it unfold at close range. The state’s principal interception body, the National Telecommunication Monitoring Centre (NTMC), grew out of the Directorate General of Forces Intelligence and now operates under the Home Ministry, with the documented capacity to intercept phone calls, emails, and social-media communications. Reporting by The Daily Star’s “Surveillance Republic” project and by the Tech Global Institute has detailed how the NTMC built an integrated lawful-interception system capable of monitoring communications originating in, terminating in, or passing through the country, drawing on equipment bought from foreign vendors, and how agencies including the DGFI and the National Security Intelligence (NSI) have acquired their own surveillance tools (Tech Global Institute, 2025). The legal scaffolding for this reaches back, strikingly, to colonial-era statutes — the Telegraph Act of 1885 among them — which is itself a Scottian observation: the colonial state built instruments of legibility to govern a subject population, and the postcolonial state inherited and digitised them.

I am not claiming that contemporary Bangladeshi surveillance is a Holocaust in waiting; that comparison would be both false and offensive, and *Night and Fog* earns its moral authority precisely by refusing easy equivalence. The claim is narrower and, I think, more durable: the underlying logic — render the population legible, sort it into categories, govern the categories rather than the people — is continuous from the punch card to the data packet. What changes is scale and friction. The camp could process a population the size of a region; the data state can process a nation in real time, at almost no marginal cost, and largely out of sight.

4. Beyond Scott: Terror, Discipline, and Erasure

Scott explains the administrative architecture of state control, but other anthropologists illuminate parts of *Night and Fog* that legibility alone does not reach. Michael Taussig, in *Shamanism, Colonialism, and the Wild Man*, examines how states and colonial regimes wield terror and a kind of cultivated mystery as instruments of power — how fear itself is administered. That attention to the psychological and ritual dimension of violence speaks to something Resnais captures that no punch card explains: the deliberate production of dread.

Timothy Mitchell's *Colonising Egypt* analyses the “technologies of power” through which the modern state disciplines and orders populations — enclosure, inspection, the model village, the schedule. His account of how order is manufactured and made to seem natural maps closely onto the camp's engineered routine. And Anna Tsing's *Friction* is useful for the film's final movement, the part about forgetting: Tsing shows how dominant powers suppress and erase the voices that do not fit the official account. *Night and Fog* ends on exactly this anxiety — that the ruins will green over, that the bureaucratic record will outlast the human memory, that the next administration of cruelty will arrive wearing the calm face of ordinary procedure. Resnais' closing warning is that the responsible parties always claim they were simply following the system.

Conclusion

Read alongside *Seeing Like a State*, *Night and Fog* stops being only a film about the past. It becomes an argument about a method of governing — one that converts human beings into legible units, governs the units, and in doing so makes it possible to administer enormous harm without ever quite confronting a person. The instruments have modernised since 1956. The Hollerith machine has become the interception platform; the inmate file has become the database; the SS administration's sorting has become algorithmic categorisation. The continuity is in the logic, not the scale of the crime, and the value of the comparison is as a warning rather than an equivalence. Resnais understood that the danger never announces itself as evil. It announces itself as

order, as security, as efficient administration — which is exactly why it is so easy to build, and so hard to see while it is being built.

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